
Symmetries in Physics — Exercise Sheet 4

Schur's lemma and the group algebra

Variant: Questions only

Exercise 1. Let ρ be a complex irreducible representation of a finite group G on V . (i) Use Schur's lemma to show that every central element z acts as a scalar, $\rho(z) = \lambda(z)\mathbb{1}$. (ii) Suppose moreover that ρ is faithful. Show that $z \mapsto \lambda(z)$ is an injective homomorphism from the centre $Z(G)$ to $\mathbb{C} \setminus \{0\}$, and deduce that $Z(G)$ is cyclic. (iii) Conclude that the Klein four-group has no faithful irreducible representation. Check (ii) on D_4 , whose centre is $\{e, r^2\}$, in the representation of Exercise 2.

Exercise 2. Take the two-dimensional representation of D_4 in Sheet 1's basis, $D(r) = R(\pi/2)$ and $D(s) = \text{diag}(1, -1)$, and the one-dimensional representation χ with $\chi(r) = -1$, $\chi(s) = 1$. Writing $D_{\mu\nu}(g)$ for the matrix elements and $n = 2$ for the dimension, verify three instances of the orthogonality of matrix elements:

$$\sum_g |D_{12}(g)|^2 = \frac{|G|}{n}, \quad \sum_g D_{11}(g) \overline{D_{22}(g)} = 0, \quad \sum_g \overline{\chi(g)} D_{11}(g) = 0.$$

Exercise 3. Find all irreducible representations of D_4 . (i) Show that D_4 has exactly four one-dimensional representations. (ii) Show that the two-dimensional representation of Exercise 2 is irreducible. (iii) Use $\sum_i n_i^2 = |G|$ to show that there are no others, and say how many times each one occurs in the regular representation.

Exercise 4. On $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ define the convolution $(f * h)(x) = \sum_y f(y)h(x - y)$ and the Fourier transform $\widehat{f}(k) = \sum_x f(x)\omega^{-kx}$, $\omega = e^{2\pi i/n}$. Prove the convolution theorem $\widehat{f * h} = \widehat{f} \widehat{h}$. Explain why it says that the basis of functions χ_k (the vectors v_k of Sheet 3, Exercise 1 — the *Fourier basis*) simultaneously block-diagonalises the regular representation.

Exercise 5. The quaternion group is $Q_8 = \{\pm 1, \pm i, \pm j, \pm k\}$ with $i^2 = j^2 = k^2 = ijk = -1$. (i) Find all one-dimensional representations. (ii) Deduce from $\sum n_i^2 = 8$ that exactly one two-dimensional irreducible remains, and realise it with Pauli matrices. (iii) Verify its irreducibility by a commutant argument. Show that only scalars commute with all the representing matrices. Explain (using Maschke's theorem) why a reducible representation would admit a non-scalar commuting operator.

Exercise 6. Without constructing any representation, use the two counting theorems of the lecture to find the dimensions of the irreducible representations of (i) A_4 and (ii) D_6 . (iii) Then construct the one-dimensional representations of A_4 from the quotient $A_4/V \cong C_3$ of Lecture 2.